

170

No. of tea gardens estimated to have been damaged, out of around 300 gardens in the Darjeeling hills and Dooars

30,000

Estimated number of livestock, including cattle, hens, goats, ducks etc. that have been lost

14,000

HECTARES

Area of flood-affected agricultural land

20,000

People evacuated; around 10,000 sheltered in relief camps

₹5 lakh

Amount to be given to the families of each of the over 40 persons killed

THE ALARM THAT THE COMBINED FORCES OF CLIMATE CHANGE and human action could spell disaster for the fragile ecosystem of North Bengal had been raised in recent years, but ignored. That proved costly, as on October 5-6, a calamity of enormous proportions struck this region of mountains, lush foothills (the Dooars) and alluvial plains watered by fast-moving streams. Over 300 mm rainfall in 12 hours triggered hundreds of landslides in the Alipurduar, Cooch Behar, Jalpaiguri and Darjeeling districts. Rivers broke their banks, roads were blocked, villages cut off or decimated. The roster of human misery read over 40 dead, with 10,000 sheltering in relief camps. "Of the 32 livestock I had, 22 are either dead or lost. In our tea garden, at least 70 families are affected," says Sikander Majhi, 41, a resident of the Tandu tea garden in the Nagrakata block of Jalpaiguri district. North Bengal had been forewarned too: on October 4, 2023, a glacial lake outburst flood in Sikkim overwhelmed the Teesta III dam and caused havoc downstream.

This latest symptom of a deepening ecological crisis is a deadly brew—rampant concretisation in river channels that reduces the capacity to absorb monsoon water, deforestation that accelerates water runoff and ever-intensifying rainfall.

Politics duly laid its fingers over the calamity. The BJP holds the Trinamool Congress (TMC) government responsible. "TMC-run authorities have allowed illegal sand mining, construction on river beds and felling of trees," says Sukanta Majumdar, BJP leader and Union minister of state for education and development of northeastern region. The TMC claims it is the state which is providing for the victims, while BJP leaders are nowhere to be seen.

The rivers that feed North Bengal—Teesta, Torsa, Raidak, Jaldhaka, Kaljani, Sankosh and their tributaries—descend from the eastern Himalayas. Often changing course, they once formed vast networks of abandoned channels and backswamps that absorbed floodwaters. But now they are undergoing rapid conversion into land for agriculture and urbanisation. A 2025 study by Jiarul Alam and others at the University of North Bengal documents this in the Raidak river basin. The total area of abandoned channels there shrank from 24.87 sq. km in 1980 to just 9.01 sq. km by 2024—a loss of nearly 64 per cent. In this same period, a much larger area of former channels comprising 104.05 sq. km was turned into farmland and 85.90 sq. km into built-up areas. Now, over 97 per cent of the Raidak basin can retain water for only 3-4 months a year, leaving monsoon water to flow across the land. Downstream districts such as Cooch Behar and Alipurduar report frequent flash floods—a pattern tied to the loss of channels. Likewise, the Torsa has lost much of its old channels to farmland. The Kaljani and Jaldhaka are heavily embanked, severing them from their floodplains. The mighty Teesta has lost tie channels that connect it to wetlands to urban expansion around Siliguri and Malbazar towns. Former flood storage zones in towns like Alipurduar and Tufanganj are now covered with buildings.

However, with the Raidak, Torsa, Jaldhaka, Sankosh and Manas entering north Bengal from Bhutan, there have been persistent demands in Bengal for an Indo-Bhutan river commission, arguing that recurring floods caused by these rivers require a mechanism like the Indo-Bangladesh Joint River Commission. "The BJP and the Centre have turned a blind eye to Bengal's demand. I had raised the question in Parliament," says Ritabrata Banerjee, TMC member in the Rajya Sabha. In answer to Banerjee's query, the Jal Shakti ministry said in August 2025 that no such proposal exists, citing existing expert groups on flood management and forecasting.

VANISHING FORESTS

In the Dooars areas of Darjeeling, Jalpaiguri, Cooch Behar and Alipurduar, once-contiguous forests are now fragmented by tea gardens, settlements and cropland. The two hill districts of Darjeeling and Kalimpong have lost 42.17 sq. km of forest cover between 2013 and 2023. These forests are vital flood regulators. They slow runoff, trap sediment, and allow water to percolate into the soil. Their loss means water rushes into rivers faster, carrying silt and debris that raise riverbeds and reduce channel capacity. The Raidak, Torsa, Teesta and Jaldhaka have become more prone to overflowing.

In hilly Darjeeling and Kalimpong,